the sky. Sunlight glared down and she made a visor with her hand. “A recruitment man came by. Wants us to work in Germany. Volunteers, he says. Did he come over on your side, too?”

“No clue.” Léa nudged a pebble with her foot. It was true what Maître Mallon had said about recruiting women with criminal records.

“There’s a one-thousand-franc bonus on departure.” She rubbed one eye. “Says he’ll send half my first month’s money up front to my mother.”

Léa angled her body away from the fence, wanting to keep walking.

“I need that money for my little boy, Raphael.”

“You have a boy? How old?” Léa said, turning back to the woman.

“Three.”

“Only three. It must be hard to be away from him?”

She nodded, her expression tense. “I’m not like the others.” She glanced at the women on the steps. “After I had Raphael, I lost my job. His father is a POW in Germany.”

“That must have been hard. What’s your name?”

“Juliette. And you?”

“Léa.” She paused. “Does your mother care for Raphael while you’re here?”

“Yes, but she has no money. Papa walked out on her before the war.” As Juliette spoke, Léa stared through the barbs in the fence—tiny metal crosses tilted sideways like mines sticking up in the air. “In Germany, I’ll be paid to work. I’ll be doing something I won’t be ashamed of . . .” Her mouth tightened. “Using my brain and not my body.” She looked at Léa, desperation in her eyes. “Do you understand?”

“Yes.” Léa had heard that prostitutes were kept in a separate part of the Jargeau camp. She shuddered to think of the poor woman’s choices: earn money as a prostitute in France or work in Germany. A bitter taste welled in her mouth. She would do the same for Rose.

“Even if they let me out in six months . . .” Her face changed. “There’s nothing here for me. I don’t want to be like them.” She edged away from the barracks toward the fence. “Just so my baby can survive.”

“How long will you be gone?”

“A year,” she said, exhaling. “It’s not too long, *n’est-ce pas*?”

“No.” The little boy would be four. She was missing Raphael’s first years.